

FACT SHEET

Name of company
EriWeave

What they do
Turn rare eri silk cocoons into fabric, and involve local women at every step

Founded in: 2019; rebranded in 2022

Annual turnover
Rs 30 lakh

Rymbai built a decentralised production network across 12–13 villages. No factory floors, no large sheds—just homes doubling as workspaces. Women farmed the cocoons, spun yarn, wove cloth and sent finished products to a small central office for quality checks and dispatch. The impact was immediate. Spinners made around Rs 5,000 a month; weavers up to Rs 20,000. For women who had never earned a rupee outside household work, even Rs 3,000 was transformative. Most are school dropouts or older women once confined to unpaid domestic labour.

a scooty for Rs 70,000, and reinvested the rest to keep the work going. Recovery came with recognition. In 2021, PRIME Meghalaya, a state government entrepreneurial programme, showcased her work, boosting both visibility and sales. A Rs 10 lakh government grant soon followed, funding new looms and a weaving shed.

The real breakthrough came on *Shark Tank India*. For Rymbai and her daughter Lebaini, who appeared on the show, the national exposure was priceless. "It wasn't about the money, but the visibility," she says. Orders poured in from across India,

"TRADITIONAL ARTS ARE DYING BECAUSE ARTISANS DON'T EARN. IF THERE'S NO MARKET, THERE'S NO MOTIVATION.... WE NEED PEOPLE FROM WITHIN TO MARKET OUR WORK, NOT JUST MAKE IT"

IAISHAH RYMBAI

But for Rymbai, this was about more than income. EriWeave preserves Khasi identity through traditional motifs and natural dyes made from local plants. "Most producers don't use natural dyes—we do," she says. While eri silk's texture may be similar across regions, the stories woven into each fabric are uniquely Khasi.

But then came COVID-19 in 2020—and a near-collapse. "I had no money left," she says. She sold her car for Rs 1.5 lakh, bought

transforming what had been a local livelihood project into a growing brand.

Production remains resolutely manual to preserve the handmade character, but sales have gone digital: WhatsApp orders, Instagram storefronts, Amazon listings, their own website, even a dedicated app. "Most income goes directly to artisans. We keep around 20 per cent," says Rymbai. Today, more than 200 women are part of EriWeave's network, a testament to its inclusive model. ■